

allocation for infrastructure, manufacturing, renewable energy, and electric mobility sectors are expected to get a boost, keeping in mind the Viksit Bharat 2047 (Developed India) vision. In the Interim Budget presented in February, the government made a record allocation of ₹11,11,111 crore for the infrastructure sector.

With the Cabinet in place, the focus has shifted now to the Budget for 2024-25, expected to be presented in July, for further indications of the government's path. To start with, the

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new Cabinet will work on the 100-day action plan prepared while the elections were underway. Some of the measures that require Parliament's approval and fund allocation are expected to be tabled during the Budget.

For now, it appears to be business as usual. But investors will closely monitor the speed of decision-making by the new coalition government and actual implementation on the ground. The results of the upcoming assembly elections in the states of Maharashtra, Haryana, and Jharkhand will be the next inflection point for the coalition. These are interesting times indeed. **BT**

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AYUSHMAN BHARAT

Caring for Health

The NDA government's flagship healthcare programme—Ayushman Bharat—needs to address concerns of streamlining the scheme and open its doors to private players

BY NEETU CHANDRA SHARMA

► **WITH THE NATIONAL** Democratic Alliance (NDA) securing another term, all eyes in the private healthcare sector are on the potential reforms to the flagship health insurance scheme, Ayushman Bharat.

The ambitious scheme, launched in September 2018, aims to provide health coverage of ₹5 lakh per beneficiary family per annum to over 500 million citizens and has been touted as the world's largest health protection programme. Although Ayushman Bharat Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (AB-PM-JAY) claims to have reduced out-of-pocket healthcare expenses for millions of families, it has faced operational challenges.

The industry says one of the major issues is delayed reimbursements to private hospitals, which has led to cash flow problems and hampered their operational efficiency. The delays in reimbursements have discouraged some hospitals from seeking empanelment under the scheme. Private hospitals have swiftly reached out to the newly-appointed Union Health Minister Jagat Prakash Nadda to convey their concerns and advocate for more efficient payment

processes.

Girdhar J. Gyani, Director General of the Association of Healthcare Providers in India (AHPI), a body representing private hospitals across India, emphasises the significance of timely payments. "The original PM-JAY scheme included a clause to pay 1% interest if payments were delayed by more than one month. Implementing this clause would ensure timely payments and encourage more hospitals," Gyani states.

As Modi embarks on his third term, stakeholders in the healthcare ecosystem are hopeful that addressing these concerns will not only streamline the scheme but will also encourage broader participation from private hospitals and ensure quality healthcare reaches

every corner of India. Rate decisions continue to be another pressing issue, with Gyani advocating for rates to be determined based on scientific studies and linked to inflation, with annual revisions. He highlighted that the current rates are generally low, necessitating a thorough review with inputs from private industry representatives.

"The National Health Authority

340
million

AYUSHMAN CARDS HAVE BEEN ISSUED SO FAR, PER THE PM-JAY WEBSITE